

Editorial

Dear readers,

The open source ecosystem of India is growing by leaps and bounds.

Rarely have I made such a bold statement. But this time, we have a lot of data to back this observation. The online service we launched recently—fossyellowpages.com (FYP)—already has over 294 Indian organisations listed. Of these, over 240 have been authenticated by the *LINUX For You* team. We have some more companies in the pipeline, with roughly two to three new players signing up every day!

Almost all major open source projects have 10 or more solution providers backing them up. Some even have over 50! The solution providers (on FYP) are spread across 18 states, and 47 cities and towns.

We realise that organisations listed on fossyellowpages.com reflect only a fraction of the whole set. We are aggressively searching for the others to invite them to join FYP. And this is where you could help us—by spreading the word and asking all firms providing open source related solutions to sign up. It's for free, with no hidden costs, yet with the prospect of getting sales enquiries from global and Indian customers.

In addition to FYP, we have also been doing a series on Indian open source players for quite a while. Every time we do a story like this, our confidence levels go a notch higher. Each organisation has taught us something new. Some have taught us how to create a niche for a company. Others have shown us how to attract talent and retain it. Yet others featured in the series have revealed the skills required to handle global customers, or conversely, make money while serving Indian industry itself.

This month we have a story on a Noida-based Web application development firm—Sakshay Web Technologies (Page 102), which is worth a read. The company has developed a sound business model, tapped the opportunities existing around open source solutions, globally, and outpaced proprietary competitors to record an annual growth rate of 60 to 70 per cent.

Interestingly, a common theme that's emerging from all these stories—entrepreneurs take note—is that in the open source world, attracting new customers is easy but recruiting and retaining talent is where the challenge lies! To address this issue, the *LINUX For You* team is trying to build a series of best practices (of Indian firms again) under the banner 'Recruitment Trends'.

"We are about to cross a threshold—when open source will be the de-facto standard and not something that we need to educate people about."

Not only will the next generation get to know about the recruitment strategies of the biggies, but will also learn about the projects and technologies in demand. Plus, we hope, that all players in the industry will get to learn from each other's best practices and make India a leader in this segment.

Let me rephrase this better—because it's a billion dollar opportunity. As of last week, leading market analysts like Gartner have warned CIOs and the IT industry to be ready for a second wave of the recession, and to control IT costs and avoid investing in expanding manpower. In contrast, there is a segment (within the same IT industry) in which vendors aren't facing any trouble getting customers. But they are having problems in scaling up to meet a galloping demand, because of a shortage of manpower.

Do you get the feeling that we are about to cross a threshold—when open source will be the *de-facto* standard and not something that we need to educate people about?

Best wishes,



Rahul Chopra
Editor, LFY
rahul@efyindia.com

PS: While we were working on the story on Kerala's IT@School project (as mentioned in the last issue) we got the good news that the Gujarat government, impressed with Kerala's example, has also decided to adopt Linux for the 3000-plus schools in the state. Hence, we held back the (Kerala) story and are now working on providing you with a bumper feature.